

Million-Dollar BABY

A \$15-million movie based on an Indian novel, directed by an Englishman, shot in Mumbai with an Indian cast, is wowing the world with its rags-to-royalty story

By Kaveree Bamzai |

Slumdogg Millionaire, the made-in-India English film currently wowing America, has a cast that pretty much reflects its hybrid nature. Three of the children who play the main characters, Jamal, Salim and Latika, are from the slums of Mumbai. The same characters in their adolescence are played by two boys from Mumbai's tony Campion School and a girl from a dance school on the outskirts of Mumbai. The characters as young adults are an even more interesting mix: Jamal is played by a British-Indian actor who had to work very hard to lose his accent, Salim is winningly portrayed by a former winner of Sony's *Boogie Woogie* and Latika is luminosity personified by a Mumbai model. And oh yes, Anil Kapoor's role of a flamboyant and somewhat Machiavellian game show host, was rejected by Shah Rukh Khan.

Shah Rukh liked director Danny Boyle, but not the role so much. Which is why on January 11, it will be Kapoor and not Shah Rukh walking the red carpet at the Golden Globes where *Slumdogg* has been nominated for four awards, including Best Picture. It's a movie whose timing couldn't be more apt. Here is a story, based on an Indian diplomat's novel, which takes the poverty of Mumbai's slums, mixes it with the grim reality of its crime-and-prostitution gangs, throws in a twist of its call centre-fuelled global profile

FIVE THINGS you didn't know about *Slumdogg Millionaire*

- ❶ Shah Rukh Khan rejected the role of Prem Kumar, which eventually went to Anil Kapoor
- ❷ Anil Kapoor was wary of playing a television host. He had just turned down playing host on the actual shows, *Dus ka Dum* and *Moment of Truth*.
- ❸ The movie was co-produced by Celador Films, who are the producers of the show *Who Wants to be a Millionaire?*
- ❹ When one of the co-financiers Warner Independent Pictures shut down, the movie seemed destined to go straight to DVD.
- ❺ When co-director Loveleen Tandan said the child actors to speak in Hindi for authenticity, Danny Boyle didn't tell the producers that one-third of the film would now be in Hindi, a box office no-no.

and puts in the transformative power of its game shows. This is a world that created Prem Kumar, the charismatic host of *Who Wants to be a Millionaire?*, who goes from famine to fame, thanks to TV. This is also the world that created Jamal, a *chaiwallah* who picks up enough English and general knowledge while working in a call centre, wins the heart of a prostitute-turned-mistress of a mafia don, and Rs 20 million as well. What could have become an exploitative tour of Mumbai's slums has become a tour de force, a sort of *Deewar* on speed. Instead of poverty pornography, there's just joyous gee-whizness.

Fittingly, the winning question in a movie that is a modern-day adventure, is about Alexandre Dumas' *The Three Musketeers*, which prized courage over all else. Fittingly, the questions cover all of India's major passions, from cricket to Amitabh Bachchan. Fittingly also, it is as ferociously optimistic as most of the other Oscar-worthy films this year have

